

THE ECONOMICS OF HESIOD'S PANDORA

Hesiod tells the myth of Pandora in two versions, the first in the *Theogony*, a cosmogonic poem, and the second in the *Works and Days*, a didactic work of wisdom literature. In each case, she figures as the outcome of a game of wits between Prometheus and Zeus that revolves around a series of deceptions and counterdeceptions in connection with an exchange of gifts. Zeus wins, of course, and in return for the theft of fire, he has Hephaistos, the artisan god, fabricate the first woman as a molded creature, who astounds men by her god-given beauty and ruins them by her thievish nature.

In recent years these narratives have attracted a great deal of attention, which can be ascribed both to the development of more sophisticated techniques for interpreting the discourses of myth and to the current interest in the cultural construction of gender categories. Newer methods address the underlying logic and coherence that govern the structure, language, and content of mythic narrative, and aim to situate a given myth in its literary and socio-cultural contexts in order to take account of its wider ideological resonances in the very processes of cultural formation. Despite differences in detail and purpose, the two versions have been taken as complements of one another, two halves of a single extended narrative that mutually illuminate the double-sided question of the origin of woman and woman as origin. Let me first recall the outlines of these two accounts.

The version in the *Theogony* begins with Prometheus' fraudulent division of the portions of the sacrificed ox allotted respectively to gods and men. Zeus chooses the inedible bones concealed beneath a covering of gleaming fat. For men is reserved the meat hidden under the unappetizing casing of the animal's belly. In angry retaliation, Zeus refuses to give (i.e., hides) celestial fire, whereupon Prometheus steals it, hides it in a hollow stalk, and brings it to men without being seen by the gods. When Zeus perceives "the gleam of fire," he counters by creating woman as a "beautiful evil" (*kalon kakon*), an "anti-fire" (*anti pyros*)—an exchange "instead of" or "in recompense" for fire. Hephaistos fashions her of earth in the likeness of a young virgin; Athena robes her as a bride in silvery garments, with a veil, garlands of flowers, and a golden crown. Thus adorned, she is an wonder to behold (*thauma idesthai*) but also a dangerous trap (*dolos*) and, brought to men, she is a continual source of woe to mortals (*pêma mega thnêtoisi*), an unwelcome supplement to those with whom she dwells.¹

Like a drone she sits within the house and reaps the toil of others into her belly. And a second evil is added to the first, for if a man avoids marriage he looks forward to an old age without any children to care for him, and his estate is divided after his death among his distant kinsmen. But even for a man who relents and takes a good wife, let us say—that is, one whose heart is in agreement with his—Hesiod still maintains that "all through life, in her and by her, misfortune will come to balance out the good."²

The version in the *Works and Days* begins with a second unhappy consequence of Prometheus' deception of Zeus in that now the gods also keep hidden from men the source of their livelihood (*bios*, i.e., the grain that must be seeded in the earth). Again in his anger at the theft of fire, Zeus determines to create a great woe (*mega pêma*) to delight men, while encompassing their destruction.³ This time, the description is recounted in far more detail.

Hephaistos molds the lovely shape of a maiden out of water and earth, with a face resembling the immortal goddesses but endowed with the "voice and strength of humankind." Athena is to teach her weaving, Aphrodite to pour grace (*charis*) over her head and "cruel longing and cares that weary the limbs." Hermes adds a shameless (doglike) mind and a thievish nature. Athena now dresses her like a virginal bride, while Aphrodite's representatives, the Graces (Charites) and Persuasion (Peitho) give her golden necklaces, and the Hours (Horai) crown her with spring flowers. At the end, Hermes names her Pandora because, as the text says, "all (*pantes*) the gods gave her a gift (*doron*), a sorrow (*pêma*) to men who live on bread."⁴

Now follows the familiar story of how Pandora was sent as a bride to Epimetheus who, although previously warned by his brother Prometheus (Foresight) to accept no gifts from the gods, in true fulfillment of his name (Afterthought), he takes her in and regrets it later. For Pandora's first act is to remove the lid of the jar, releasing all the evils and diseases that now silent and invisible wander over the earth and, by Zeus' will, only Hope or Elpis is left behind in the jar,⁵ an ambiguous quality to whose meaning we will shortly return.

We owe the most influential analysis of this myth to the French scholar, Jean-Pierre Vernant,⁶ (with further elaborations and refinements/correctives by Nicole Loraux and Marilyn Arthur [Katz]).⁷ Vernant demonstrates a series of homologies, inversions, and correspondences between all the different elements in these

narratives: the various animal parts of the sacrifice apportioned by Prometheus (*Theogony*); the fire first hidden, then stolen, then hidden again (*Theogony, Works and Days*); the grain now hidden in the earth (*Works and Days*); the jar that conceals all evils (*Works and Days*); and the first woman, lovely to look at but defined as a belly (*Theogony*). Taken together, these now define the new and permanent quality of human life—its ambiguity and deceitfulness—a mixture of evils concealed under beautiful exteriors and virtues under ugly ones.

In one or another of her aspects, Pandora herself corresponds to each term of these several transactions that always operate under the seemingly opposite modes of giving or not giving gifts (hiding/stealing), but that on closer inspection prove to be variations on the single theme of giving through concealment and trickery. Like the sacrificial portion of food offered to the gods, Pandora has a beautiful exterior and a worthless interior. Like the portion offered to men, concealed in the paunch (*gastér*) of the ox, she is a hungry belly, insatiable of food. Above all, in inverse return for the celestial fire stolen by Prometheus, the woman comes equipped with a thievish nature and is later likened to a fire that consumes man by her appetite for both food and sex.⁸ Seed, on the other hand, applies to the germ of technological fire, which, unlike its celestial parent, must now be engendered and stored in a hollow container (the narthex stalk): it applies too both to the seed the farmer must plant within the earth as well as the one which he deposits in his wife's belly to produce children.

Pandora therefore emerges as none other than the symbol of ambiguous human life. In her appearance, her gifts given to her by the gods, she echoes the divine. By her bitch-like mind and the primacy of her bodily requirements she approaches the bestial. By her human voice and status as wife she is human. But, as Vernant concludes, she is also the reverse of man, forming another breed that is fundamentally different from him. Man and woman cannot converse with one another because she conceals the truth in order to deceive. At the same time, the conditions of her creation establish the fundamental triad of activities that are central to Greek views of culture: sacrifice (relations of men and gods), agriculture (men and nature), and marriage (men and women). The last two categories are especially linked in Vernant's discussion by the analogy, so familiar in Greek thought, which likens the woman to the earth and gives men the task of seeding both the womb and the soil.

Viewed from a cross-cultural perspective, however, the story of Pandora can be classified as a variant of a wide-spread myth that both creates woman as a secondary category following the creation or prior existence of men and also associates her creation with the origin of what is conveniently called the "human condition"—that is, with bringing death and evil into the world along with the laborious toil of human existence. While the Greek version subscribes to this general aetiological pattern, it goes much further in its negative evaluation of woman as a separate and alien being, the first exemplar of her race or species, the *genos gynaiikôn*.

In the first place, woman is not created as a companion to assuage man's loneliness, as we are told, for example, in the biblical account of Adam and Eve (*Gen. 2:21*),⁹ but rather as a punishment (not even merited through human fault). Second, there is no reconciliation after the fact, since male and female retain a drastic asymmetry without any basis for a division of labor that would make them ultimately partners, albeit unequal ones, in the conduct of mortal existence. Thus, while Vernant's reading of the cultural implications of the myth of Pandora remains valid in general terms, it cannot explain the special features of Hesiod's economy—his insistence on the fact that only men work while women remain perpetually idle, compared to useless drones who sit within the house, "filling their bellies up with the products of the toils of others"¹⁰ and providing a source of endless resentment.

Women could contribute to the household, for example, with their typically feminine skills of weaving, already given by Athena to Pandora.¹¹ Male and female could be active in their respective domains, as Xenophon's *Oikonomikos* prescribes, the man working outside to increase his household's wealth and the woman managing the inside stores. Above all, as wife and mother, woman is herself also a giver of gifts, because she produces children from her belly and gives them nurture (*trophê*).

Hesiod only elliptically acknowledges that woman is needed to provide offspring, viewing this reliance as a second source of evil that follows upon the first complaint that had characterized her as a drone: "Whoever avoids marriage (*gamos*) and the baneful works of women (*mermera erga gynaiikôn*), and will not wed, reaches deadly old age without anyone to tend his years (a *gêrokomos*), and though he at least has no lack of livelihood while he lives, yet, when he is dead, his kinsfolk divide his possessions amongst them."¹²

All is inference. Nothing is stated directly—neither sex nor procreation. We typically take this passage to mean that if the creation of woman interrupted the presumed commensality of men and gods, when they shared the same food, it also confronted man with a mortality which she alone can remediate through the compromise of providing progeny to take care of him in his old age, children who will live on after his death and, as his substitute(s), maintain (and increase) the fruits of his labor. But in extracting this reading, we also fail to take the full measure of the evasions and ambiguities that complicate both this text and that of the account in the *Works and Days*, where, in the context of agricultural labor, woman's sexual and reproductive roles remain still more discreetly obscured. Let us take a closer look.

First is the problem of sexuality itself: a natural instinct, fueled by the mysteries of desire and accompanied by pleasure in sexual contact, yet also fraught with ambivalence. In Hesiod, woman's beautiful exterior, enhanced by alluring adornments, elicits only the *thauma* (wonder) of the gaze,¹³ while the *pothos* (desire) she arouses in the *Works and Days* through Aphrodite's influence is qualified as "painful" (*argaleon*), linked only to "cares that devour the limbs."¹⁴ We note further that in both texts, far from "cleaving



Figs. 1-4. Details of a neck amphora from Basilicata. The figures have been interpreted as Pandora rising from the ground; a youth; Epimetheus; and Elpis (Hope), who remains in the pithos. London, British Museum, inv. no. F 147, late 5th century B.C.

together and becoming one flesh” as the biblical account tells us (*Gen.* 3:24-25), or even “mingling in love (*philotès*),” as the euphemism in Greek texts (and elsewhere in the *Theogony*) would have it, man and woman remain distinct and disjoined entities. Pandora may be arrayed as a bride in a proto-version of marriage and given as a wife to her foolish husband Epimetheus in the *Works and Days*,¹⁵ but nowhere, oddly enough, are we told of any carnal activity between them or again, as the parity of the biblical story suggests, of a mutual awareness of themselves as genitalized beings once they have come into their fallen state (cf. *Gen.* 2:25 and 3:7).

The dangers of sexuality as encroachment on the autonomous male body and the potential imbalance of its humors, the limitations or qualifications set to its unrestricted enjoyment, its separation from a specified love object, and the attribution of unbridled (extravagant) sexual appetites to women are characteristic and recurrent features of Greek attitudes. Later medical and philosophical texts will spell out the dangers to men’s health in taking sexual pleasure, as Foucault’s astute analysis reminds us,¹⁶ but the framework in its most negative form is already in place in Hesiod, particularly in the context of woman’s creation as an *anti pyros*, a “fire” that takes the place of the one that was stolen. Sex is treated as an unequal transaction by which woman steals man’s substance, both alimentary and sexual, and by her appetites even “roasts man alive and brings him to a premature old age.”¹⁷ Thus in the *Works and Days* men are later warned to beware of making love in the summertime, because this is the time when “women are most wanton, but men are feeblest, since Sirius, the Dog Star, parches the head and the knees and the skin is dry through heat.”¹⁸ No wonder that sexuality is viewed as a less than mixed blessing, since men and women do not share the same rhythms or seasons of desire, and woman’s desire, in any case, consumes the man and robs him of what is his own.

But the second and corollary point may be more essential. This is the ambivalence about women’s reproductive capacities, which may account even better for the notable imbalances we find in Hesiod’s economic system. As Loraux points out, in the *Theogony* woman is not even modeled in “the canonical image of the reproductive good wife. If the text implies that with the woman, marriage appears and therefore reproduction, the function of fecundity is hidden. Nothing indicates that the woman is expected to ‘imitate the earth’ as the standard Greek representations of fertility suggest.”¹⁹ On the contrary. Hesiod separates woman from the bountiful earth by inverting the usual etymology of her name from an active to a passive construction, from the one who gives to the one who is given. Not “the giver of all gifts,” as a related epithet of Gaia (Earth) indicates, “Pandora” is here glossed as “the one to whom the gods have given all gifts.”²⁰

Additionally, the suppression of woman’s fertility also means ignoring the value of her experience in childbirth, the *ponoi* of her suffering and travail. In other Greek contexts these are sometimes made equivalent to the trials and labors (*ponoi*) of men engaged in battle and other heroic endeavors, exemplified in Medea’s famous statement that she would rather stand three times in the van of battle than bear a single child.²¹ In Hesiod, by contrast, only men have *ponoi*, the doleful exertions of daily life, attributed in fact to woman herself who has imported them into his present existence.²²

The significance of these two omissions is again reinforced by comparison with the parallel story in *Genesis* of Adam and Eve: Expelled from the garden of Eden, the male is condemned to bring forth his daily bread by the sweat of his brow (i.e., agriculture) and the female to bring forth children in pain and travail (*Gen.* 3:16-19). Their mutual dependency is further emphasized by God’s earlier injunction that they be fruitful and multiply, populating the earth with their numberless progeny (*Gen.* 2:28).

So to put it briefly, the biblical story reflects not only a shared existence and responsibility, once woman has been created, it suggests an economy of abundance, proliferation, and expansiveness, while the Hesiodic tale is rooted in an economy of scarcity, parsimony, and man's anxious surveillance over what he has patiently accumulated by himself and for himself.²³ To cap it all, far from being characterized in the *Theogony* as the "mother of all mankind" as Eve is named (Hava) in the biblical account (*Gen.* 3:20), Pandora is described instead as the origin only of the *genos gynaikôn*, the "race of women," as though to deny, or at least, to elide the drastic notion that men are from women born.

What factors might account for this harsh outlook on life? What are the underlying issues in Hesiod's account that sees woman only as a rapacious and famished belly, "a companion to Plenty but not to Poverty," a creature who takes everything without giving in return? Various socio-economic explanations have been proposed: (a) a change in methods of agriculture, particularly the plough, better suited for men, that devalues women's contribution to subsistence, (b) a disembedded social organization of the Greek polis in this Archaic period (8th century) in which the private *oikos* or household is separated from communal, especially, public life, (c) a growing scarcity of land and resources relevant to this age of colonization, and (d) class distinctions between aristocratic and so-called peasant attitudes.²⁴

All these hypotheses may be valid to some degree with respect to the proposed time and place of Hesiodic composition, but they cannot account for the enduring prestige of these texts, particularly, as the canonical account of the creation of the present world order under Zeus' hegemony (over against competing versions). Hesiod's extreme rancor toward woman, while open to compromise and mitigation in other spheres of interest, still remains the touchstone of an underlying attitude concerning this intrusive and ambivalent "other," who is brought into a strange man's household and forever remains under suspicion as introducing a dangerous mixture into the desired purity of male identity and lineage,²⁵ whether in sexual relations or in the production of children.

A further point is that in both texts, Pandora's creation is an integral part of a larger and more complex narrative. Each time she is a means to other ends, introduced as the outcome of a quarrel between two males over the apportionment of rightful shares. In the *Theogony*, her story is a part of the larger struggle for power among divine forces, the result of the strife between Prometheus and Zeus. In the *Works and Days*, Hesiod's dispute with his brother Perses over the division of their inheritance leads to the use of the Pandora myth as both explanation and admonition, accounting for the current conditions of our existence and warning what men must do to survive in the harsh environment of the Iron Age.²⁶ Yet in both versions, Pandora's creation marks a conclusive rupture between men and gods, which means that her presence not only defines the categories of male and female in the human sphere but also stands at the intersection of relations between gods and mor-

als. Given the anthropomorphic nature of Greek divinity, mythic discourse habitually dramatizes the issues of gender, sexuality, and reproduction from a double perspective, and perhaps nowhere more clearly than in the confrontation between divine and human worlds underlying the two Hesiodic accounts. Given the limitations of space, I will confine my analysis to the human world—the status of children and problems of production and reproduction in the household.

Household Economies

There is a persistent strain of ambivalence in Greek thought about the nature and value of children, who, although treasured as bearers of the family line, are also a source of potential disappointment and sorrow. They may turn out well, of course, but, like the woman herself, they may eventually bring trouble to a man's household. A reference to just such an idea may be implied in an ambiguous passage in the *Theogony* that concludes Hesiod's remarks about marriage and its discontents:

For a man who chooses to marry and gets an agreeable wife...
evil still continually contends with the good,
but [for] he who meets up with an *atartêroio genethlê*
lives always with unceasing grief in his heart,
and this is an evil that cannot be healed.²⁷

The crux of the problem lies in the interpretation of *genethlê*. Does it mean "race" (i.e., of women) or "progeny" (children)? If *genethlê* refers to woman, then the passage contrasts two kinds of wives: a good one (in which case, the negative still vies with the positive) and a baneful type, whose effect is unrelieved misery and woe. On the other hand, if we ask *why*, even in the case of an agreeable wife, evil is still said to contend with the good, then we may prefer to read *genethlê* as "progeny," since, even under the best of circumstances, children may well prove a mischievous bane to their parents. Each reading has its merits, and since the word appears nowhere else in Hesiod, scholarly opinion remains divided.²⁸ But this uncertainty may well be the essential point,²⁹ as reflecting the double ambivalence about women *and* the necessity of having children, the latter most fully expressed in the famous choral ode in Euripides' *Medea*:

...those who have never had children, who know nothing of
them,
surpass in happiness those who are parents.
The childless, who never discover
whether children turn out as a good thing
Or as something to cause pain, are spared
many troubles in lacking this knowledge.
And those who have in their homes
the sweet growth of children, I see them always
worn down by worry.

First how to bring them up well and leave them something to live on.

And then whether all their toil is for progeny who may turn out well or not remains unclear.

Finally [I paraphrase here], even under the best of circumstances, death may still carry them off.³⁰

Even more decisive, however, for my argument is the fact that the vexed passage in the *Theogony* containing *genethlē* occupies virtually the same structural position in the narrative as does the mention in the *Works and Days* of the *Elpis* or Hope that remains in Pandora's jar. Each text marks the conclusion of the episode, each followed by a similar tag line: "So it is not possible to deceive or go beyond the mind of Zeus,"³¹ and "So there is no way to escape the mind of Zeus."³² In context, *Elpis* functions as yet another ambiguous quality that also shares in this world of mixed good and evil, a sign of the uncertainties of the future to which human life is now consigned, good if it inspires men to work and assure their livelihood, to fill their *pithos* (jar) with grain, bad if it lulls an idle man into illusory expectations for the future.³³ But taken as an image that embodies an idea, the *Elpis* that is left in the jar most closely corresponds to the child (or the hope of the child) residing in its mother's womb. In this reading, Pandora's *pithos* can be correlated with the *gastēr* (belly), her defining feature in the *Theogony*, and like the *gastēr* of the sacrificial portion that contained the edible portions of the ox, the *pithos* too is an independent repository that conceals something within.

References in other texts to the child as the *Elpis* or Hope of the household provide a telling argument for this identification.³⁴ But a more precise indication is the fact that later medical and philosophical texts associate and even correlate the womb with a container or jar. Throughout the Hippocratic corpus and the works of later, more sophisticated anatomists, the woman's uterus is likened to an upside-down jar, furnished with two ears or handles. The *stathmos* or *pythmēn* (in Latin, the *fundus*) refers to the base or bottom of the jar now located on the top, the *stoma*, *os*, or mouth, lies at the bottom, and the neck (the *aychēn*, *trachelos*, or Latin *cervix*) opens in a downward direction. The jar/uterus is modeled on features of human anatomy. It too has a mouth and a neck. This nomenclature is also pertinent to the wide-spread idea of a correlation between women's sexual and oral appetites, emphasized in the Hesiodic text as located below in the rapacious belly (*gastēr*) that fills up on man's substance. Popular and medical notions insist on a symmetry in woman between the mouth and the belly, as reflected, for example, in a number of prescriptions for gynecological therapy. A jar, as in Hesiod, has "lips" (*cheilē*),³⁵ and so does a womb.³⁶ The analogy continues in the notion of a seal or stopper that is needed to prevent entry, with the aim of preserving virginity, or, conversely, to retain the seed deposited in it in order to allow a successful pregnancy to occur.³⁷

What does it mean then that Pandora comes equipped with her own jar, and that she removes the lid to open it, releasing a swarm of ills that now wander silently and invisibly all over the world, leaving only Hope within? This action is what now determines man's condition—that he will suffer "ills, hard toil, and heavy sicknesses which bring the fates of Death upon him,"³⁸ with only Hope to deceive or console him. *Elpis*, of course, is a general, even abstract concept. Yet we may understand it better in the light of Pandora's actions. If the implicit analogy between Pandora and the jar holds true, then it is difficult to escape the conclusion that to open the *pithos* is equivalent to the breaching of her virginity, while to close the jar upon the *Elpis* that remains within marks the beginning of pregnancy, not yet brought to term. Under these circumstances, it is equally difficult to resist the idea, even though nowhere directly stated, that what escapes from the jar equally escapes from the vulva in the most negative encoding of female sexuality,³⁹ and Hope or the child, uncertainly placed between evil and good, is the single best, if still unsatisfactory, result.⁴⁰

Even more to the point in Hesiod's text of the *Works and Days* is the preference, explicitly stated, for a family consisting of a single child: "There should be an only son (*mounogenēs pais*) to feed his father's house, for so wealth will increase in the home."⁴¹ The prospect of a second son elicits the ominous remark that in that case, better to die old, or as the text is often read, the only son in turn should have another only son.⁴² We find this attitude also expressed elsewhere,⁴³ but in the Hesiodic economy in which women and offspring are viewed only instrumentally and only in relation to the dynamics of masculine acquisition and retention, the possible proliferation of children is viewed as a significant threat.

Woman is therefore defined as an economic liability. If her continuing reproductive capacity is to be tapped only once, thereafter she is an unnecessary surplus who does not increase the household wealth, but rather with her gluttonous appetite for both food and sex, she diminishes the resources of both house and husband. She thus neither resembles the fields that are worked outside nor the once bountiful earth of the Golden Age. Marriage and agriculture may be understood as two related spheres in which men toil and deposit their seed, but in the case of Pandora, they are also disjointed. If man once took freely from the unstinting produce of earth, woman now takes from the abundant stores accumulated by man, who, since her creation, has had to become the sole author of his own sources of nurturance.

Finally, the emphasis on raising an only child has a more pointed significance if we consider its thematic relevance to Hesiod's personal status as represented in the *Works and Days*. He is certainly *not* an only son: the entire poem is framed as a protreptic exhortation to his good-for-nothing brother Perses. We cannot recover the full details of Hesiod's complaints, but two issues seem to be evident. First, Hesiod has been in some kind of litigation with his

brother over the division of their father's estate. Perses has somehow acquired more than his share by stirring up quarrels and has bribed the judges to sanction this unfair division. He has encroached on property that is not his, that rightfully, in fact, belongs to Hesiod. If brothers must share, the portions at least ought to be equal, thereby satisfying the demands of *Dikê*, or Justice. But having one heir and one heir only to the patrimonial estate would do more than forestall the possibility of a fraudulent division leading to destructive Eris (Strife)—it would obviate the need for any division at all.⁴⁴

At one level, as Vernant has observed, the dispute between Hesiod and Perses concerning the fair division of their inheritance parallels the unequitable sharing of the sacrificial meal in the *Theogony* between Zeus and Prometheus. But the characterization of Perses in the *Works and Days* also gives rise to a second analogy, for this Perses is an idler who must be persuaded to accept the divine necessity of labor, so that he does not end up as a burden to others or even as a beggar. "If he had filled himself up with a year's supply of grain in reserve," says Hesiod, "then he could turn to the quarrels and strife in the agora to lay his hands on another's goods."⁴⁵ It is after this first address to his brother, in fact, that Hesiod tells the story of Pandora as the founding myth of why men are obliged to work and to accumulate the means of life through agricultural toil.

In the *Theogony*, as we have seen, Pandora is compared to a useless drone, "no companion to Poverty but only to Plenty," who sits within and consumes another's goods. In the *Works and Days*, we learn that the gods gave her a shameless mind and a thievish nature. Perses, we may note, combines both her qualities in his unregenerate state. Like Pandora, he is deceitful and thievish.⁴⁶ Like her, he intends to acquire for himself what belongs to another. Like woman, he is an idler who does not work and belongs with Hunger (*Iimos*) rather than Satiety (*Koros*), and he too is "like the stingless drones who waste the labor of the bees, eating without working."⁴⁷ Pandora is the opposite of the "bee wife," who, as the Archaic poet Semonides tells us, is the single and only paradigm of the virtuous wife. Perses, in turn, is a bee with no sting in him, a drone, like the woman within the hive that is the house, assimilated now to her earlier identification as a drone in Hesiod's *Theogony*.

Two inversions therefore come into play. First is the opposition between animal and human worlds, in which the bee community inverts the usual division of roles to assign the active part to the female and the passive one to the male.⁴⁸ Although the woman-drone seems to occupy a position reserved for males, the analogy is operative only with regard to the management of the household, which, like a hive, consists of bees and drones. The industrious woman may well be compared to a bee if she fulfills her domestic functions, or if not, she can be called, as here, a lazy drone who fills her belly with the fruit of another's work. For the man, however, whose place is out of doors and in the fields, the image of the drone in the hive can only apply if he loses his masculine dignity by refusing to work (*aergos*) and, like a woman, by living off the toil of oth-

ers. Thus despite the proper alignment of male and drone, the indictment of Perses only attains its full resonance as an allusion to the Pandora of the *Theogony*—Pandora, whose story is told to Perses yet again, now in the context of the god-given necessity that decrees men must now earn their living by tilling the fields. In short, if Perses is a drone, it is because woman, in negation of her positive image as the bee wife, provides a pertinent analogue to Perses himself.

The result is that Pandora occupies a double position in Hesiod's system of the household. She is, first of all, the potential overproducer of progeny, who, in bearing more than one child, poses the risk of a fraternal rivalry that is exemplified in the *eris* between Hesiod and Perses. Yet she also serves as the model for Perses himself: a drone, a supplemental and unwelcome addition who takes what is not hers rather than working or giving in return.

Perses, however, may be persuaded to assume his proper masculine role and to enter into the economy of labor by which he may rightfully prosper as well as participate in the generalized social rules for exchange and reciprocity. ("Give to the one who gives, but do not give to the one who does not give.... Give (*dôs*) is a 'good girl', but Seize (*harpax*) is a bad one, the giver of death").⁴⁹ Pandora, by contrast, remains ambiguous, excluded from participating in the household economy. Defined as an outsider, unwillingly brought by the man inside his house, she carries within her belly the equally ambiguous Elpis who, even if turning out well for man's future, is still restricted to the grammatical category of the singular (*mounê*), not the plural.

Several important consequences attend this Greek view of woman's origin and functions. We note first by contrast that the myth of Adam and Eve justifies both the social, even organic, dependency of wife upon husband and her subordination to his authority, the first through her birth from Adam's rib after his creation, the second through God's specified punishment for Eve, along with travail in childbirth, that her husband rule over her. Yet in Hesiod, oddly enough, while woman's inferior status is strongly implied, the husband's control over his wife is not established as a "natural" social rule. Woman seems in fact to retain an intrinsic power over man. She can, by her appetites, enfeeble and impoverish him, seduce him and rob him. ("Do not let a flaunting woman coax and cozen and deceive you: she is after your barn").⁵⁰ Man has no effective means of retaliation, no sure way of exercising his authority. He can perhaps only minimize her inherent danger by taking a young wife, as he later advises, and hoping thus to socialize her in his ways.⁵¹ But in essence, his only options are to avoid woman by shunning marriage altogether, thereby losing his patriline and irrevocably fragmenting his substance, or to suffer the miseries she inflicts upon him. On the other hand, by undermining the woman's maternal functions of both nature and nurture, the myth separates her from the true underlying sources of her power. The story thereby ratifies woman's secondary and derivative status in man's household, emphasized all the more by the mode of Pandora's own

creation, since as an artisanal product, accompanied by another artisanal product (the jar), she is also separated at the outset from the natural processes of generation by which the entire universe came into being.

In sum, the remarkable feature of Hesiod's versions of the origin of woman is precisely the elision of physical contact between the sexes. In its further refusal to utter the name of "child," the text not only cannot name the woman as mother, but also cannot empower the male as the father. The relationship between man and woman is rather an economic one, framed in the disparity between producer (he) and consumer (she), between ownership and appropriation, abundance and lack, between self and intrusive other. As a result, paternity too is commodified, translated elliptically into economic terms as the requirement of the male ego. Man needs the support of someone to tend him in his old age and to conserve and increase the legacy of his material assets. Fatherhood means the continuation of his property in the hands of his heir. The triumph of paternity is projected instead into the world of the immortal gods—in particular, on Zeus who is *both* the first and only instance of a divine child requiring nurture *and* the sovereign ruler who earns the title "father of gods and mortals." Thus it is only the gods who can accomplish what men desire and dream of, exempt from both time and death, but if the price for mortals is high, it is probably woman, in the final analysis, who must pay the greater share.

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1. Hesiod, *Theogony* 561-91.
2. Hesiod, *Theogony* 594-609.
3. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 46-58.
4. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 59-82.
5. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 56-104.
6. Vernant (1980b) 168-85 and (1989) 21-86.
7. Loraux (1981) 75-117; Arthur [Katz] (1982) and (1983). See too Pucci (1977).
8. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 704-706.
9. I acknowledge but do not discuss here the problem of the two accounts in *Genesis* of human creation, the first of which suggests that male and female came into being at virtually the same time ("And God created man in his own image, in the image of God created he him; male and female created he them" [1:27]). Both versions, however, insist on the parity of one male and one female, destined to form the first couple.
10. Hesiod, *Theogony* 599.
11. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 63-64.
12. Hesiod, *Theogony* 602-606.
13. Hesiod, *Theogony* 575, 581, 582, 588.
14. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 66.
15. Cf. Hesiod, *Theogony* 511-14.
16. Foucault (1985).
17. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 705.
18. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 586-89.
19. Loraux (1981) 88-89.
20. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 80-82.
21. See Loraux (1989b) and (1989c).
22. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 90-92.
23. The economy of scarcity and parsimony is best summarized in Hesiod, *Works and Days* 354-69. On the biblical worldview, see, for example, Eilberg-Schwartz (1990) chap. 6 and Cohen (1989) chap. 1.
24. See, for example, Sussman (1984).
25. See especially the fine study of Pucci (1977).
26. Vernant (1989) 32-35.
27. Hesiod, *Theogony* 607-12.
28. Many scholars prefer "wife," including West (1966) *ad loc* and Snell, *Lfgre*, s.v. *genethelê* (see also, Loraux [1981] 95 n. 103), but the dilemma remains unresolved.
29. Woman and child can often be conflated, as, for example, in the parable of the lion cub in Aischylos, *Agamemnon* 681-749. The problem of *genethelê* in Hesiod is heightened by yet another ambiguity in that the preceding passage never mentions the word "child" at all. What we hear instead is that "the man who does not marry...reaches baneful old age without anyone to look after him" (605). This caretaker or *gêrokomos* is a word invented for the occasion (and found only here in Archaic and Classical literature). It is sufficiently obscure that West (1966) *ad loc* feels obliged to make clear that the text refers to "the son, not the wife," a claim he deduces (not without reason) from the well-known rule that the son is expected to provide *gêrotrophia* for his parents in return for his own nurture. So too, in the sentence that follows, the son as heir to his father's possessions is not named but merely implied; his identity is inferred in fact from the alternative, that in his absence, it is distant kinsmen (*chêrôstai*) who will later divide the man's estate (605-607).
30. Euripides, *Medea* 1090-1110.
31. Hesiod, *Theogony* 613.
32. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 105.
33. For convenient summary of the many views on *Elpis* (as good, bad, or both), see especially Verdenius (1985) 66-71; for bibliography, Noica (1984). I concur for the most part with Vernant (1989) 78-86, that *Elpis* is an ambiguous quality (like *Eris*, *Zêlos*, *Aidôs*, and *Nemesis*).

34. Significantly mentioned in funereal epigrams (e.g. *Palatine Anthology* 7.389, 453) and grave inscriptions nos. 661 and 720 in W. Peek, *Griechische Vers-Inscripten*. vol. 1. *Grab-Epigramme* (Berlin 1955).
35. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 97.
36. E.g., Aristotle, *History of Animals* 7.3.583 a16.
37. For the medical texts, see Hanson (1990) and (1992). See also Sissa (1990) 53-70 (on mouth and uterus) and 158-62 (on virginal closure). On the idea of a seal or stopper for the uterus, see Hanson (1990) 324-30, who, dissenting from Sissa, distinguishes between the mouth of the uterus and that of the labia. Sissa (1990) 156, understands the pithos in Hesiod as the belly of the woman ("a faithful and fertile wife") but does not discuss the status of Elpis.

For the equation of child and Elpis, see Hoffmann (1986) 55-89, (72-76), who notes the correspondence between marriage (Hesiod, *Works and Days* 800) and opening a pithos (Hesiod, *Works and Days* 819) in Hesiod's agricultural calendar, but argues for a different significance.

Might we take *mega pōma* (stopper) of the jar as a pun on *mega pēma* (bane, e.g., Hesiod, *Theogony* 592), as the first woman is called?
38. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 90-92.
39. This is a hypothesis I cannot prove from ancient evidence but can only surmise.
40. Also instructive is a little-known myth, preserved in several late texts (Parthenius, *Erotika* 28; Nicolas Damascius, frag. 19, scholiast to Apollonios of Rhodes, *Argonautica*. 1.1063; Eustathius, *Iliad* 357, 43f.; and Strabo, 13.621c). Piasos, a ruler of the Pelasgians, conceived a passionate desire for his daughter, Larisa, and raped her. Her vengeance was as follows: observing him leaning over a huge pithos filled with wine, she seized him by the legs and plunged him headfirst into the cask where he drowned. See Rudhardt (1981) 739, who is mystified by the tale, but the correlations are not difficult to find. Her action both parodies his plunge into her "pithos" and fittingly repays him in kind, since the use of wine was typically restricted to men, who had access to the containers (pithoi: cf. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 359-69: "Take your fill when the jar is first opened and then again when it is nearly spent" and cf. 597-603). Sexual and alimentary appetites are neatly joined, with the added fact that wine is the substance that encourages sexual desire. "Drunk" with passion, he drowns in a surfeit of his own lust.
41. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 376; cf. 271.
42. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 378. So (West) 1966 *ad loc* and, among others, Pucci (1977) 111. I prefer the first interpretation, which gives a straight progression: one, two, or many sons, but best to have only one. In the case of a second son, you should die old (presumably after having acquired sufficient wealth to divide it), and if you have many, then you need Zeus' assistance, since he can "easily bestow prosperity." As West remarks, this is "a typical Hesiodic provision for exceptions to the general rules at the discretion of the gods."
43. This attitude is not restricted to Hesiod, whatever the economic conditions of his day might have been. Its continuation in the tradition is already mentioned by the various scholia (vetera) *ad loc*, following Plutarch's commentary. See e.g., Xenocrates frag. 97, Aristotle, *Politics* 1274b19ff., and Plato, *Laws* 740b-d, 923cd, referring to optimum family size and population control in the Greek polis. Also, e.g., Golden (1975). Space does not permit a fuller discussion that, among other issues would have to include exposure of the newborn.
44. The scholiast at 376-78 already notes why Hesiod would prefer a *mounogenēs*.
45. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 33.
46. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 322.
47. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 303-304.
48. On the problem of bees and drones and gender inversion, see Loraux (1981) 82 and Vernant (1989) 68-73. Roscaglia (1988) argues on the basis of ancient evidence that drones are not viewed as males, per se, but rather constitute an alien *genos*, which, like Pandora, enters another's dwelling. Yet, given that "drone" is a masculine noun and "bee" a feminine one, there is no reason, as Roscaglia does, to limit the terms of the analogy.
49. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 354-56.
50. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 374.
51. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 700.